

The Needs of Students and Faculty at a Southern-Suburban High school and the Efficacy of an Intervention

Word Count: 4274

Introduction

It is obvious that high school students today face a variety of stressors that can negatively impact their overall quality of life, but rising suicide rates of this age group show how essential it is to provide help for all children. Suicide is “the second leading cause of death for people 10 to 34 years of age” (“Preventing suicide”, 2019). Mental health education and awareness must happen early on in life when children as young as ten consider killing themselves as the only option to escape a bad situation. Since there is no way to control how parents interact with their kids, schools become the easiest way to reach out to these children; problems within the school system should be identified and mended to ensure real change can influence the lives of many.

The majority of literature on student psychological needs-assessments typically pertain to rural and urban schools, because they are more likely to face issues such as gang violence or transportation difficulties. These complications stem from the community around the school and not the school system itself, which is why it is important to study suburban schools, which on average, encounter fewer problems of this nature. The experimental high school is a suburban school that has experienced several student suicides, providing an area of study with proven poor mental health, which is mostly removed from the community issues found in rural and urban schools.

Drastic tragedies such as suicide will impact community wellness and the feeling of emotional safety within, which is why it is so crucial to start preventative matters as soon as possible. The need to uncover and ameliorate the stresses that these students face is apparent, which is why this project asks: how do we assess and address the psychological needs of students and faculty in a classroom setting at a southern-suburban high school?

Literature Review

To have a multifaceted discussion of school needs, it is imperative to view all participating perspectives under the lens of academic research as well as these perspective's views of other parties involved. Most research on school-needs is done through student self-reporting or teachers providing their insight on student behavior through tests, usually on a one to five scale for rating behavior. If the research goal of a project is to determine the way one group views themselves or others, this is a beneficial method. Otherwise, it potentially clouds the purity of the resulting data. However, since the goal of this project is to gain insight into subjective views, this method is adequate. This literature review will discuss and analyze research in the areas of school-needs assessments, the perspective of other roles in a school environment, and intervention methods.

Needs-Assessments

In an analysis of LGBT youth's experience in school written by Craig, McInroy, and Austin, the researchers conducted a needs-assessment among non-conforming and minority youth. Poor states of mental health among these children was evident, the suggested cause of this was discrimination and bullying. The researchers found "despite help-seeking behavior, LGBT youths continue to disproportionately have mental health needs that remain unmet." which results in stronger feelings of isolation and hopelessness. (Craig et al., 2018, p.232) Yet, the methods of treatment and help suggested by the researchers were simple and easy to implement, such as having one adult mentor such as a close teacher, or the implementation and maintenance of a GSA (Gender-Sexuality Alliance) club. Since the experimental high school already has a GSA, taking the approach of mentorship for students may be more beneficial to all students and not just LGBT and racial minorities.

The article “Exploring Urban Hassles and Psychosocial Needs for Urban High Schoolers in a School-Wide Needs Assessment” focused on the environmental stressors, which high-schoolers living in an urban area frequently face that students in other environments rarely do. However, this article first addresses nation-wide problems concerning mental health, according to the National Comorbidity Study Adolescent Supplement (NCS-A) an astonishing “21.4%” of 13-18 year-olds currently experience severe psychiatric disorders and this number will increase to “46.3%” over the course of a lifetime (Haddad et al., 2017 para. 2). Because the possibility of developing a psychiatric disorder increases over the lifespan it makes sense that children should be taught to develop coping mechanisms within school. The researchers state that “Of all students in the United States, over ten million require mental health intervention with over 70% relying on public schools as the location to receive care” (Haddad et al., 2017 para. 2) but, many more students are undiagnosed, meaning that they will receive no care. The authors claim that everyday stressors may contribute more to a negative quality of life than severe traumatic and life-changing events. Through the researchers’ survey of high school students, they discovered that the self-rating of disturbance for the same types of events varies from student to student. The researchers suggest that these students may simply be better equipped to cope with certain events. To improve the coping mechanisms of all students, the authors recommend that schools implement community outreach programs, as well as access to web-based education on various social issues.

The article “Identifying Students with Emotional Disturbance: School Psychologists’ Practices and Perceptions” focuses on the quality of life for students with emotional disturbance as identified by teachers. The authors found that between “18% and 22%” of students have a diagnosable psychiatric disorder, from this group the “Judge David L. Bazelon Center for Mental Health Law ([24]) estimated that more than 80% of youth with mental and emotional disorders

were not identified” (Hanchon et al., 2013, p.194) meaning that they would not receive treatment or accommodations regarding their mental health. The researchers claim that mental illness progresses with age and becomes more difficult to ameliorate which is why every effort should be taken to identify and help those affected.

A study by Hoffman, Anderson-Butcher, Fuller, and Bates explores the relationship rural students have with their school. The researchers claim that social relationships improve academic performance overall and since rural students are typically isolated from each other and have fewer opportunities to involve themselves in school activities, they may be at a disadvantage. Other studies in this paper discovered that “rural youths in their study displayed a higher prevalence of anxiety (39 percent) compared with that of the general adolescent population (10 percent)” (Hoffman et al., 2017, para. 7) The researchers found that rural schools have a higher prevalence of bullying which may contribute to anxiety. Hoffman and others claim factors that cause limitations in social activity result in higher dropout rates among rural schools as compared to urban and suburban schools.

Perspective of Others

To analyze how adequate school psychologists feel in their role in identifying student difficulties Cleary, Gubi, and Prescott surveyed psychologists from a myriad of school environments. The researchers found that most school psychologists rely on self-reporting scales to identify student problems rather than other assessment types. They claim that school psychologists should receive more training on other methods to increase the accuracy at which they evaluate children. The authors claim that students in urban schools need more attention than suburban students because of the quality of their environment (Cleary et al., 2010). The perspective of school psychologists is important to take into account because they deal one-on-one with students and are referred to scholars who struggle in school.

The paper “Suicide Prevention Experiences, Knowledge, and Training among School-based Counselors and Nurses in King County, Washington - 2016.” brings focus to school nurses as well as counselors. Nurses are able to identify possible suicidal, depressive or, anxiety-like tendencies. Students may have identifiable self-harm scars or symptoms associated with anxiety such as panic attacks, increased heart rate, and trembling. Because students are more likely to disclose personal health information regarding these issues to someone in a health profession they have a greater opportunity to help their patients, which is why the perspective of nurses should be considered. The research shows that nurses and psychologists have a lack of training in suicide prevention which will affect their performance when handling a currently suicidal student. The researchers state that these positions should receive more training which emphasizes at-home prevention such as suggesting to parents to lock firearms and prescription medication. (DeCou et al., 2019)

Interventions

The intervention of group therapy was used in “Empowerment Groups for Academic Success: an innovative approach to prevent high school failure for at-risk, Urban African.” This report analyzed the mental well-being of a group of African-American girls after attending group therapy which was held in school. Group therapy proved to be a more beneficial method than one-on-one therapy, even showing long-term positive effects after the intervention. The authors claim that this method should be implemented across all schools specifically for minority groups so they can relate to each other (Bemak et al., 2005). A group therapy service for at-risk students would be easy to implement, possibly even preferable to the school counselors/therapists as their current workload cannot accommodate all students in need.

One novel intervention implemented by Dolan was “A teen hot line” where a group of teenage volunteers were trained in peer counseling and managed a hotline where other

adolescents could call and discuss sensitive situations with a peer. There is no quantitative evidence that the hotline helped people as the calls are confidential. However, the hotline kept receiving frequent calls suggesting that it did promote the well-being of adolescents (Dolan, 1995). While this intervention would be difficult to implement because of the time needed for each volunteer regarding training and managing the hotline, this is something that could reasonably be implemented within five years.

A study conducted by Passaro, Moon, Weist, and Wong discusses the use of reality therapy on children with emotional disturbance (mainly ADHD and ODD). Reality therapy is a form of cognitive-behavioral therapy that focuses on implementing problem-solving strategies. This example also uses the feedback of teachers to determine progress for individual students. There was a small improvement in most teachers however, the researchers state many limitations including teacher's tolerance for student's outbursts increasing causing the actual perceived improvement. Despite this, the authors advocate reality therapy over prison time; they also state that more authority figures within schools need to take up counseling roles to promote real student improvement (Passaro et al., 2004). While this article does provide specific procedures for conducting reality therapy, the minuscule increase in positive behavior indicates that it will have a higher opportunity cost than all other methods. However, the guidelines on managing students and conducting forms of therapy can serve as useful in other forms of intervention.

One study focuses on what makes a school environment pleasurable for students with attendance issues in "School characteristics that influence student attendance: experiences of students in a school avoidance program." Obviously, a hostile school environment encourages absenteeism but, the most quoted disturbances were group punishments and physical fighting within classrooms. The most quoted positive factors regarding the school avoidance program

were a smaller population, opportunities for community involvement, increased opportunities to socialize with peers and feeling respected by teachers and other staff as well as “teachers’ flexibility with deadlines and options to redo work [show] signs that teachers cared about his academic success” (Wilkins, 2008, p.19). While this intervention would be impossible to implement in an already existing educational institution, analyzing the student-teacher relationships in this school to add to teacher training may provide some benefit to the overall school environment as well as creating more social and leadership opportunities for students.

While this research does provide an adequate background on school needs-assessments and other topics regarding this field of research, there is a prominent gap concerning suburban schools and the entire student body of a facility instead of a minority group. This paper will address the gap within the following methodology.

Methodology

A mixed-method approach including a survey to collect quantitative and qualitative data through means of a Likert scale and written in questions as well as multiple interviews of faculty working at the experimental high school were created in Google Forms and used to conduct this school social analysis. This method was chosen to mirror the design of “Exploring Urban Hassles and Psychosocial Needs for Urban High Schoolers in a School-Wide Needs Assessment” because it was the most practical for the high school environment when the available resources of time and authority were taken into consideration. However, the design of that paper was modified to include in-person interviews so that the results could contain more qualitative data. The findings of the pre-survey were thematically coded to understand the nuances of selected problems and the opinions of students and faculty members. The results of these findings create the basis for the intervention plan which will then undergo analysis in a similar survey as the pre-test. The post-test also undergoes thematic coding to evaluate if the

intervention successfully ameliorated the problem, had unforeseen benefits, lacked to address certain areas of targeted improvement, created new issues and the student's and faculty's overall opinion of the intervention's impact.

The survey created for the project split the responses from faculty and students into two different sections to distinguish the results from each other and ease the process of comparison between the two groups. Each group answered 22 questions, 2 of which were demographic, 19 asked the individual to rate a social problem by severity and frequency on a Likert scale of 1-5 (one being "strongly disagree" and five being "strongly agree") with the question phrase "I believe that X is an issue within our school" and the remaining question allowed the taker to input their own opinion on school social issues and their views of intervention plans. Before being sent out, the survey was peer-reviewed by both class members and faculty willing to help. This survey was sent out through the district email service ensuring that all members of the community had an equal opportunity to participate. For extra measures the survey was promoted in school group chats and social media such as Facebook.

Interviews were held with a wide array of faculty. Faculty members included positions of therapist/counselor roles, teachers, and school administrators, several faculty members had experience in multiple roles and at multiple schools. This experience in multiple fields served as a reference point to compare to the experimental high school. Interviews with faculty members were in-person interviews to keep the dialogue natural and relevant to current issues students are facing. These interviews intended to determine the interviewee's view of the school and policies, possible solutions to social issues, student/faculty relationships as well as faculty/faculty relationships. All qualitative evidence collected was thematically coded to reveal common trends and themes for the issues community members noticed.

Findings

The initial survey yielded 138 total responses, 28 of these were from faculty and the remaining 110 from students. Two of the student responses had to be deleted for false answers (students selected every possible demographic including that they were 9th, 10th, 11th, and 12th grader all at once) leaving a total of 136 responses to be analyzed. Out of the faculty responses, 82.1% were teachers, 7.1% were counselors, 3.6% were administrators, and the remaining 7.2% were a single media expert and a member of support staff. Six total faculty members gave invalid responses to the written response (wrote N/A, none or I don't know), leaving a total of 22 written responses to thematically code. Within the student section 40.7% were seniors, 39.8% were juniors, 9.3% were sophomores and 10.2% were freshmen, the vast majority 65.7% were currently taking at least one AP course. Six-teen total students gave invalid responses (wrote N/A, I don't know, etc.), leaving a total 92 responses to thematically code.

Faculty Initial Survey:

Table 1

Raw Data For Faculty

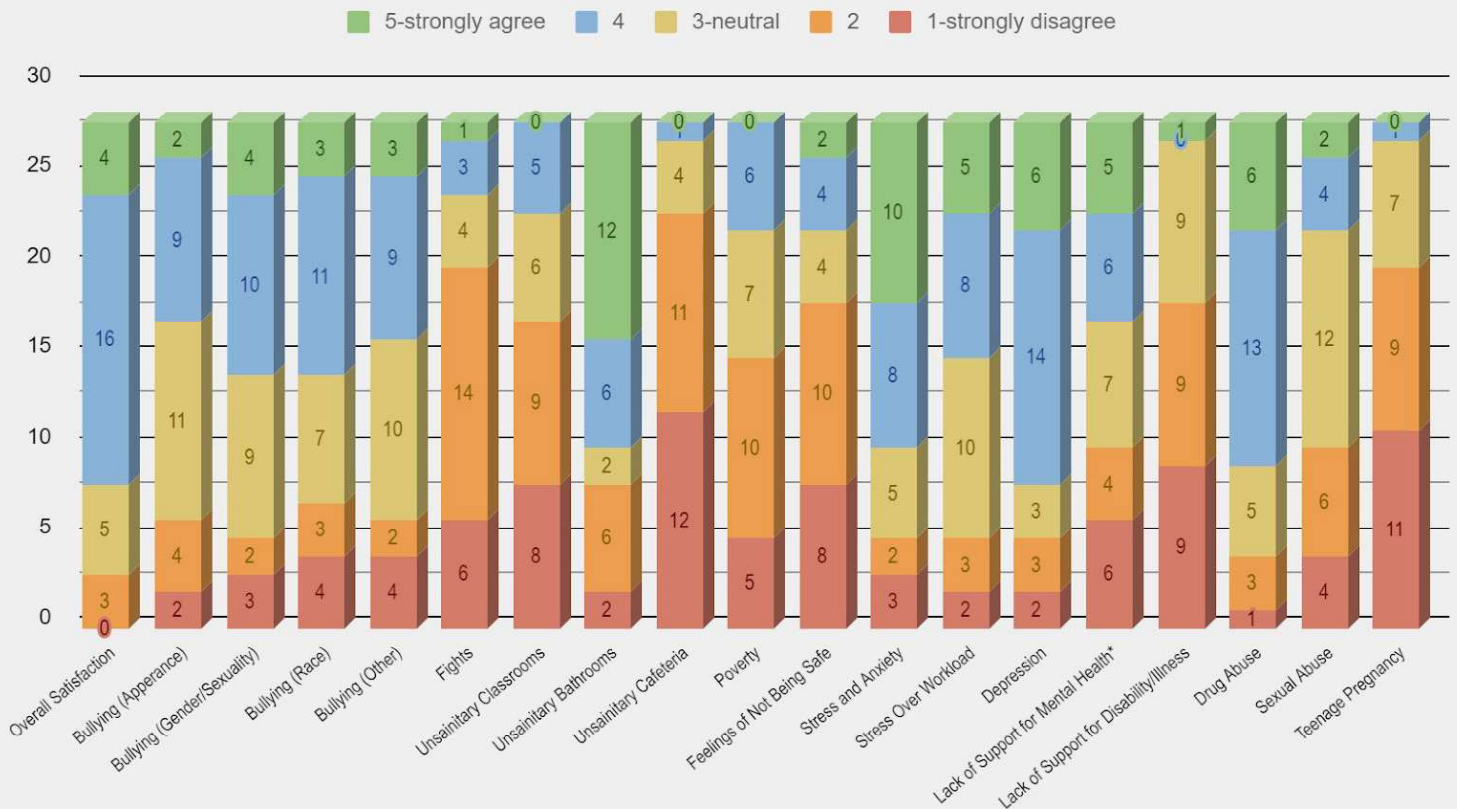


Table 1 shows the raw data from the initial survey. This table is provided to supply insight as to how the mean values were calculated. It is also a useful tool to visualize how dispersed the data is spread. Refer to “Lack of Support for Mental Health*” this question received a nearly even spread of ratings indicating that the prevalence and severity of this problem varies widely from person to person. Questions such as “Overall Satisfaction”, “Depression”, and “Drug Abuse” have a large number of neutrally rated responses. This may mean that the question could have confused respondents, or that it is difficult for an individual to rate the issue.

Table 2

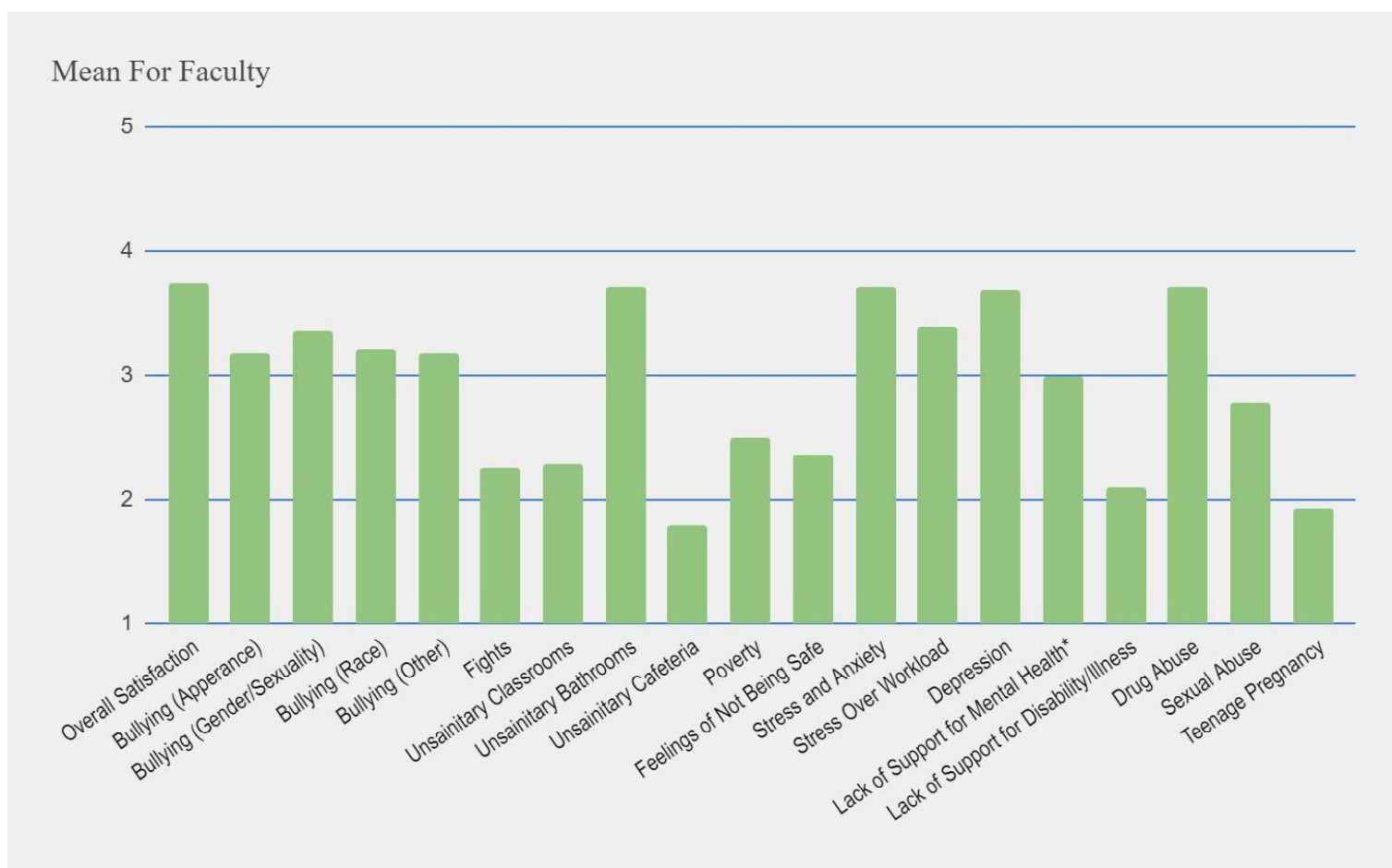


Table 2 depicts the mean values for each question. This data can be used to determine which issues are significantly impacting faculty members' work. For the faculty section, no

specific issues reached a mean to be considered detrimental. In fact, the question which received the highest mean score was “I am satisfied with my overall school environment.” Even though most faculty members have an overall positive outlook on the school’s environment “Unsanitary bathrooms”, “Stress and Anxiety”, “Depression”, and “Drug Abuse” are areas with room for improvement.

Table 3

For Faculty: Identified Problems	# of Responses Which Identify Problem ▼
Mental Health Support	7
Bullying	7
Tense Relationship Between Students and Faculty	4
Phones or Social Media	2
Restrooms	2
Support for Specific Needs	2
Lack of After School Tutoring	1
Lack of Consistency in Punishment	1

Table 3 sorts through the written-in response question in order to provide qualitative data. This question asks “Please write the most distressing social issue to you (can be one not listed) and describe a possible intervention you think would help with the listed issue.” The results of this were categorized by similar themes. Even though “Lack of Support for Mental Health” and all bullying questions had dispersed responses (Table 1) resulting in low mean scores (Table 2) the fact that they are the most cited problems in written in response questions indicates that the faculty members who see these issues are very impassioned by them.

Student Initial Survey:

Table 4

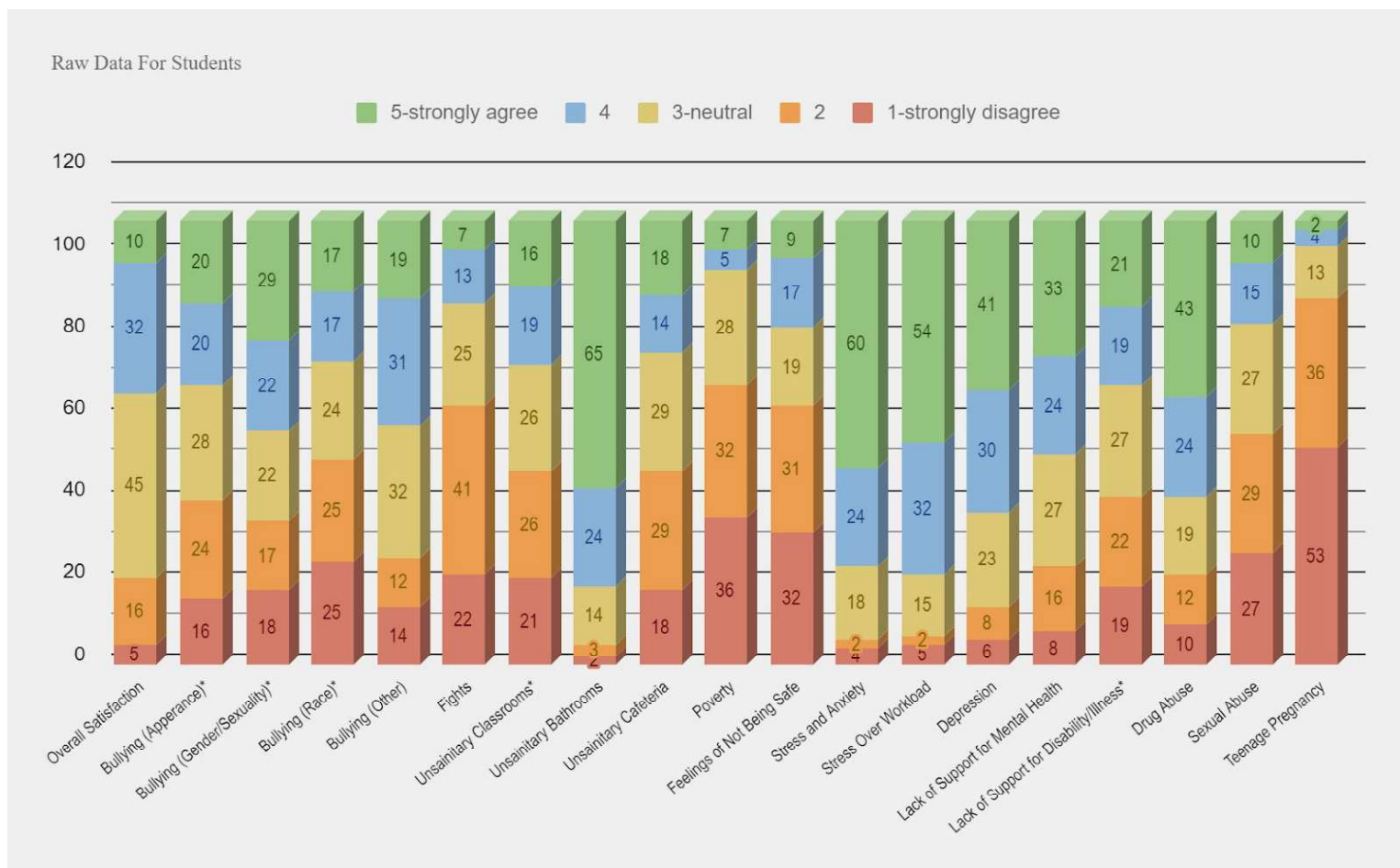


Table 4 shows the raw data responses from the student survey. The even spread of answers in all bullying questions, “Unsanitary Classrooms”, and “Lack of Support for Disability/Illness” may indicate that only certain students come into contact with these issues. “Overall satisfaction”, and “Bullying (other)” have large neutral populations, these questions could have been difficult to rate, or the question itself may confuse the respondent.

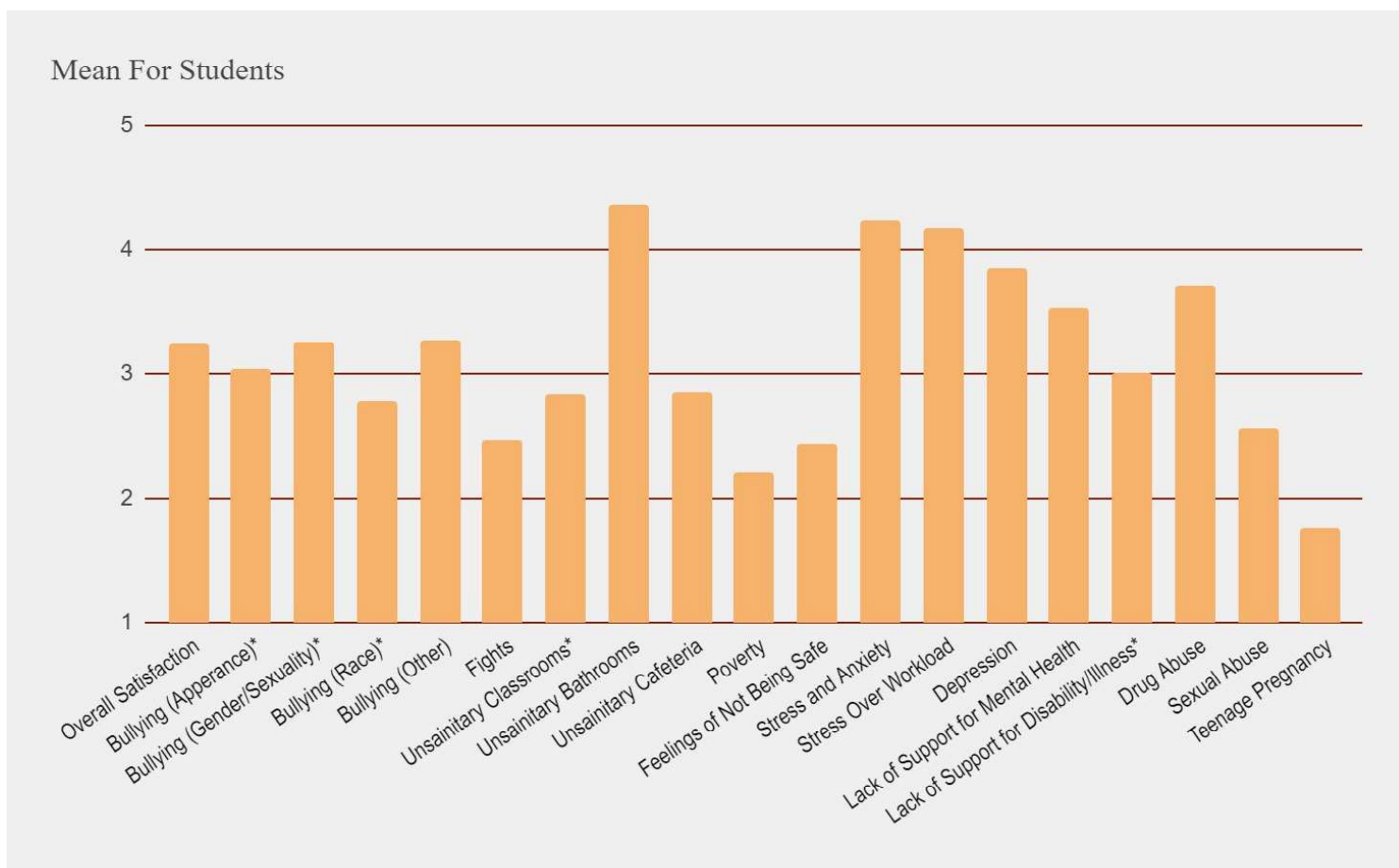
Table 5

Table 5 shows the total mean scores for each issue, this reveals concerning data about the school environment with “Unsainitary Bathrooms”, “Stress and Anxiety”, “Stress Over Workload”, “Depression”, and “Drug Abuse” receiving very high mean scores. Except for “Stress Over Workload” these are areas in which the faculty also rated relatively high because of this, the intervention plans will attempt to target these issues.

Table 6

For Students: Identified Problems	# of Responses Which Identify Problem ▼
Lack of Support for Mental Health (Significant overlap with stress over workload)	32
Judgements on Other Students (Significant overlap with bullying)	28
Stress Over Workload (Significant overlap with lack of support for mental health)	19
Bullying (Significant overlap with judgements on other students)	13
Judgements on Faculty (Significant overlap with bullying, mental health, and sexual abuse)	13
Bathrooms	11
Drug Abuse	10
Sexual Abuse	4

Table 6 contradicts some of the results in Table 5, "Lack of Support for Mental Health" was the most cited from the qualitative data. This shows that even though it received a low score on the mean data table, this is the most distressing issue for the people it affects even if it is not a universal problem across the student body. "Judgements on Other Students" was included because it commonly came up in student responses, this may lead to students isolating themselves if they have negative views of others and can, therefore, be linked with feelings of loneliness, depression, and anxiety. Most "Judgements on Faculty" answers accused faculty members of not helping students with their specific issues, this can highly exacerbate what the student body experiences especially in situations of sexual abuse; every answer in sexual abuse mentioned faculty as not doing enough or victim-blaming.

Interviews:**Table 7**

Coding for Interviews N:4

Faculty Member A - Therapist	• Most severe issue: lack of support for mental illness • Reported higher rates of bullying and drug use but less teenage pregnancy than a rural school • Perspective changed to include all student problems and the politics of school • School faculty needs to be sensitive to student's mental health and allow them time to heal • Staff needs to work on collaboration with each other in order to care for students • The school needs to provide trauma-based education to handle situations with students if they are not willing to send them out of class
Faculty Member B - Teacher	• Most severe issue: bullying and drug use • Reported higher rates of bullying but fewer fights than an urban school • Perspective changed to include previous experience when dealing with issues • School faculty should intervene when they see a bullying situation, even though the student may not physically get hurt the long-term emotional impact may be more damaging than a fight • Believes that seminars where students are asked to stand up when the speaker lists a problem that they have experienced
Faculty Member C - Therapist	• Most severe: bullying based on race • Found a trend of schools which have low diversity have higher rates of bullying • Perspective changed to include the environment that children are raised in, likely contributes to their prejudice against other groups, also developed an understanding of the issues which minority groups face • Faculty should teach diversity and react to bullying situations swiftly • The school needs to add more disciplinary measures for students who continue to bully others, staff should make an effort to use inclusive language when talking to students.
Faculty Member D - Administrator	• Survey did not address cyberbullying • Most severe issue: bullying • Could not compare other schools to this one due to the change of culture with time • Perspective changed because of the cultural changes with time • Faculty can refer students to new programs on campus such as the drop-in clinic • The school needs to find a more effective way to handle cyberbullying but we do not currently know a more effective way

Please refer to appendix A to place these summaries of answers into the context of the questions. Interview transcripts are located in appendix A. Most faculty interviewed agreed that bullying is the most severe issue at school, except for A who states that lack of support for mental health is the most severe. By comparing differences from other types of high schools' results between faculty members A, B, and C (as D could not provide an answer) there seems to be an emerging trend that a lower (and therefore less diverse) population experience more

bullying but, according to B fewer fights. There can not be comparisons between the remaining answers because three or more faculty members did not answer in similar ways. While the suggestions for improvement provided by faculty members were feasible they could not be implemented with my current resources and authority.

Conclusion

While this research was unable to confirm and answer the question most administrators and teachers had “can these social issues even be fixed?” it does fill part of the gap left by a lack of school-analysis research on suburban schools. While these specific results cannot be generalized it is safe to say that every high school does and will encounter social issues and any test on these problems brings us one step closer to ameliorating them or at least making the people within the studied environment feel heard. It is our societal responsibility to curate a safe and comfortable learning environment for today’s youth.

Limitations

Several limitations need to be taken into account for this research to be fully understood. Many of these pertain to most school-analysis papers, such as the inability to generalize these results to all schools or even all schools within a district. The sample size was limited so the research does not include every possible perspective and has more representation from upperclassmen than any other group. This sample is also affected by volunteer bias, even though every worker and student had access to the survey only ones who wanted to answer, filled out the form. While two survey forms were removed for definite sarcastic/false answers other answers may also be false. The survey itself is also susceptible to error, while I attempted to eliminate any confusing questions in the survey by having beta testers analyze and review it, some participants could still not understand the questions asked. I also failed to add questions

on cyberbullying, judgment of students, and judgment of faculty. However, these are all subsets of the bullying question, and participants did have the opportunity to write in issues if one of these were particularly distressing. I did add in “Judgements of other students” and “judgments of faculty” into the coding charts because several written in responses included data which fit into these categories, however, no student mentioned cyberbullying and only one faculty member explicitly mentioned cyberbully though, “phones and social media” responses may have been referring to cyberbullying.

The interview portion could have also been impacted by the same limitations however, the people interviewed did have the liberty of asking the question to be clarified. The people had a bigger incentive to lie about answers because of the social pressure of talking to a student.

Thematic coding of qualitative data was vulnerable to my personal biases and misinterpretation of data. While I attempted to remain completely neutral while reviewing responses, it would be irresponsible to state that I have no bias. However, I did take extra precautions while sorting data and triple-checked all responses to ensure I was correctly representing both the interviews and survey written-in responses.

The final project goals did not get completed. These last goals were to establish an intervention plan which was intended to be a dispersal of hotline information, a meet-and-greet table for lonely students, and the implementation of a bibliotherapy solution for bullying-based disciplinary measures. Following these interventions there would be another survey distributed to analyze if they lead to any improvement to the social issues which were targeted, these surveys would be thematically coded in the same way as the initial pre-survey and the results of both would undergo a comparative analysis. Because of the quarantine safety measures in response to the COVID-19 pandemic I lost access to the testing site and willing participants. Despite the lockdown due to pandemic, I feel that if administrative approval was given within the

two-week period I predicted these interventions could have been enacted. Administrator approval was received the last two days before the school closed down or roughly a month and a half after it was initially sought. However, a spot for the table was not confirmed upon. The survey process would have likely been dispersed through emails and social media probably after schools closed down, the results of which would have been interfered with due to panic surrounding world issues nevertheless it could have yielded important results to further the field of school-analysis.

Implications for Further Research

Future research should be conducted at all schools in order to determine each's social atmosphere, this should be done every four years so that each set of classes can be analyzed. With the authority of school administration, a school analysis can quickly be conducted with no cost so long as they are using free programs such as Google forms. However, if the school administration conducts this research they will likely be subject to sarcastic answers from students as well as students withholding information because they fear persecution. The initial pre-survey provides a small benefit of increasing the school's reputation among students and faculty members but, it is ultimately worthless if not followed by an analysis of the results and plans for intervention. The interventions decided upon will expectedly cost resources of time, labor, and money. Because of this, it is wise to provide a post-survey to determine if the intervention provides a significant benefit. With in-depth research regarding these interventions, administrators can wisely choose the best options for their school's social issues.

By bridging the gap in school analyses there is more information for scholars to base their research on, and this research can help distinguish confounding variables in connection with social issues. This will help isolate the variables for further study and lead to more targeted solutions in fields and environments other than school psychology.

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